it result in efficient control or in blocked arteries and, finally, a heart attack? Democratic regimes choose to use modern information technology to distribute the flow of information between more institutions and individuals and encourage the free pursuit of truth. They consequently have to struggle with the danger of fracturing. Like a solar system with more and more planets circling faster and faster, can the centre still hold, or will things fall apart and anarchy prevail?

An archetypal example of the different strategies can be found in the contrasting histories of Western democracies and the Soviet bloc in the 1960s. This was an era when Western democracies relaxed censorship and various discriminatory policies that hampered the free spread of information. This made it easier for previously marginalised groups to organise, join the public conversation and make political demands. The resulting wave of activism destabilised the social order. Hitherto, when a limited number of rich white men did almost all the talking, it was relatively easy to reach agreements. Once poor people, women, LGBTQ people, ethnic minorities, disabled people and members of other historically oppressed groups gained a voice, they brought with them new ideas, opinions and interests. Many of the old gentlemanly agreements consequently became untenable. For example, the Jim Crow segregation regime, upheld or at least tolerated by generations of both Democratic and Republican administrations in the United States, fell apart. Things that were considered sacrosanct, self-evident and universally accepted – such as gender roles – became deeply controversial, and it was difficult to reach new agreements because there were many more groups, viewpoints and interests to take into account. Just holding an orderly conversation was a challenge, because people couldn't even agree on the rules of debate.

This caused much frustration among both the old guard and the freshly empowered, who suspected that their newfound freedom of expression was hollow and that their political demands were not fulfilled. Disappointed with words, some switched to guns. In many Western democracies, the 1960s were characterised not just by unprecedented disagreements but also by a surge of violence. Political assassinations, kidnappings, riots and terror attacks multiplied. The murders of John F. Kennedy and Martin Luther King Jr, the riots following King's assassination, and the wave of demonstrations, revolts and armed clashes that swept the Western world in 1968 were just some of the more famous examples.[124] The images from